

Having One Single Standard for Open Source Licensing Compliance is Crucial

The OpenChain Project makes open source licence compliance simpler and more consistent, thus enhancing trust in the open source software used to build solutions. Mishi Choudhary & Associates (MCA) is the India law firm partner of the OpenChain Project and organiser of the ‘MCA OpenChain India Working Group Meetup’, which was held virtually earlier this year. Speakers at this event were **Keith Bergelt, CEO of Open Invention Network; Shane Coughlan, general manager at OpenChain Project; Mishi Choudhary, founder and managing partner, MCA; and Ramakrishna Yekulla, senior specialist solution architect with Global Partners and Alliances at Red Hat.** This article touches upon what each speaker said at this meet.

Shane Coughlan, general manager at the OpenChain Project, is an expert in communications, security and business development. In his address at the virtually held ‘MCA OpenChain India Working Group Meetup’, he said, “At OpenChain, we have an international standard for open source licensing compliance. Having one single standard changes the entire field of copyright in open source. All of the uncertainty that we previously had while managing these licences is now gone. In 2021, our mission is to make sure that the standard goes deep into the supply chain and that it’s used for sales, advertising, procurement, and so on.

“We spent years to develop and refine this standard. User companies collaborated over a considerable period, putting in thousands of hours to develop the standard precisely to ensure that not only do we meet the licence requirements effectively, but can also increase efficiency. Because it is efficient and simple, OpenChain allows us to dramatically reduce resource costs in open source licence



compliance. We have a very simple process of going through a supply chain to identify where a mistake or failing may have happened.

“OpenChain as a standard has great potential. During the long time we took to build this standard, we have explicitly and consciously built resources to support companies in adoption. We have over 1000 documents including checklists, templates, and guides. These are reference documents created by user companies to help others. We have an online and downloadable self-certification questionnaire to help companies adopt the standard on their

own terms and at their own pace. We have built a global network of partners, including MCA, to support companies who are adopting OpenChain or refining their process. We have local workgroups in many jurisdictions including China, Japan, Korea, Taiwan, India, UK, and USA.

“In India, we have such an interesting and vibrant ecosystem. We have innovative Indian companies making products and solutions. We have a tremendous outsourced technology industry as well. For the Indian market, we are in the early days. We do have partner companies such as the MCA. But we have such a big market space in India with thousands of companies. India might be the pivotal area for us. If we can work with the large system integrators and outsourcing companies, I think we might be able to accelerate the adoption of this standard. In doing so, it will dramatically reduce costs as well as risks. When it comes to key geographies, we are looking at India, China and virgin markets like Brazil,” said Coughlan.